state and an empire. These deeds made various civilising advancements possible as well as an economy that for many centuries was the most important in the world. Nevertheless this would not have been possible without a strong control over peasants and the workforce due to an iron bureaucracy – in particular, the army – and a generalised civic ideology such as Confucianism able to uphold it. Thus it was that water management permitted rice field irrigation, enabling the workforce to be fed while disciplining it and making it capable of building huge engineering works. This was the case of the Great Wall in whose construction more than ten million people died. Behind this kind of work there was interplay between population control and government involvement.

Past Chinese potency entered into crisis when European powers obliged the empire to open its borders. The most dramatic episode was the Opium Wars in the mid-19th century when England, which controlled the commerce of this drug, used its military to force China to allow drug consumption in its interior. England also forced the import of raw materials, particularly textiles, as well as the use of the Chinese workforce in English factories relocated to China. In this manner Europe turned trade to its advantage at the same time it occupied Hong Kong.

European intervention and the Japanese invasion during World War II that demanded control over natural and human resources caused the traditional system of domination to enter into crisis. The relationships imposed in China became suffocating for the majority of peasants and workers who took part in various revolts (Wolf 1999) that culminated in the revolution led by Mao Zedong with general peasant support. Nevertheless, during the revolutionary era, the Chinese economy had already deteriorated due to colonial pillage, World War II damages, and the very same popular war led by Mao.

It should be noted that the same revolution would turn to disciplining and preparing the population for agricultural and industrial work. In fact, among the measures taken after the triumph of the revolution in 1950 the industrialisation process known as the Great Leap Forward stands out, from the end of the 1950s and beginning of the 1960s. From Mao's perspective, which was absolutely anti-colonial and at the same time admiring of European industrialisation, it was necessary to modernise China at all cost. This implied work quotas that caused famines and the death of millions due to abandonment of the countryside. Once Mao's measures were applied, the country began recovering military power, developing heavy industry and building a strong state able to control the population, to displace traditional elites as well as to ward off foreign powers, including the Soviet Union.[1]